



the nets makes you a better bowler tactically.

Thinking like a batter will help in the long run because you're anticipating outcomes from their perspective and guarding against them. Maybe that's why Shafali Verma could come in and take those two wickets in the World Cup final (laughs)."

The joy of cricket in whatever form

Nothing compares to donning the India blue for Shikha, who is also a retired squadron leader in the

Unbroken thread — Jemimah and Shikha...

Careers drift, dressing rooms change, but some cricketing relationships survive the churn untouched.

Indian Air Force. But the joy of playing and consuming the game is the same, no matter the level. In a sense, that cushioned her World Cup-watching experience as India ticked off one of her biggest career ambitions: winning the World Cup.

"It hurts that you don't make the team. And sometimes it is even difficult to watch the games. But then, we need to realise that the situations that we are put in are not in our hands, but our reactions to them are." This is something a longstanding mentorship with Australian legend Belinda Clark taught Shikha.

Shikha's struggles were not all internal. Her parents and sister also witnessed the uncertainties and mental toll of rejection.

"Three years ago, my sister Vibha, who works for Oracle as a project lead, told me she would be supportive if I decided to walk away. She said, 'You're good enough, you'll get a job anywhere based on your academics (Shikha is an engineering graduate). She still asks me why I continue to play this game. This is from someone who is the reason I am still playing this sport.'"

A network that matches her never-say-die attitude has played a major role in keeping her going. She credits her family, coach Nitin Vernekar, former India team physio Tracy Fernandes and Naresh Ramadoss (who run a High-Performance athlete-centred fitness centre called *Athleap* in Goa) and Nasiruddin Thameesdeen and Nooruddin S. at Just Cricket in Karnataka (where she regularly trains) among others for keeping her afloat, giving her more than just shoulders to cry on. Her network has

facilitated training spaces, cricketing help, and moral support in a growingly cut-throat world.

Her own interest in the science behind an athlete's life has also been crucial.

"As a science graduate, I was also interested in ways to train better. I bought *Whoop* (a performance-tracking app) in 2022, when few had it. I have a *Garmin* (sports wearable) when training. I have always been interested in metrics. Once I got a niggle and went back and checked the data about my left leg's contact point and whatnot. Tracy ma'am had to stop me sternly.

"I carry my own compression boots. I know I am not a 16-year-old anymore. I am blessed. Despite not being in the national setup, I have the resources to have a nutritionist - Tenzin."

Ray of hope

A World Cup win, Shikha hopes, will bring those systemic changes.

"The (wish) list is so long. For starters, proper domestic contracts for cricketers, not exaggerated amounts, but just start somewhere if a woman cricketer needs a good kit, a nutritionist, and other support. That's why WPL comes. If you have more teams added, a lot more domestic players will get in. For long, we've had one solid employer in the women's game (Railways), so those avenues need to improve for players."

She also credits the BCCI's age-group tournaments for being the stepping stone the women's game long needed.

"I've had teammates who left the ecosystem after the Under-19 level because they weren't good enough to make the senior level yet. Now you have the U-23 tier, there's the U-16s as well. Whole batches of players were wiped out because such levels didn't exist before. There's so much more to be done.